

What Is Content Marketing?

You've just heard someone mention "content marketing" and you get the idea you should already know what it is, but you're too embarrassed to ask anyone. Congratulations, this post is for you.

The Content Marketing Institute, an online resource for information on all things content marketing related, defines content marketing thusly:

Content marketing is a marketing technique of creating and distributing valuable, relevant and consistent content to attract and acquire a clearly defined audience – with the objective of driving profitable customer action.

The key word here is "valuable." It's what changes this definition from one that could describe almost any form of advertising or marketing. You can tell if a piece of content is the sort that could be part of a content marketing campaign if people seek it out, if people want to consume it, rather than avoiding it. So was VW's 2014 "Game Day" commercial, which has been viewed on YouTube almost 18 million times as of the writing of this post, an ad, or content marketing? The answer is it's both, depending on how it's received by each individual who is exposed to it. The same will apply to any piece of content marketing you create, depending on whether the recipient received value from it or not. Of course the goal is to provide as much value from your content marketing to as much of your target audience as possible. At this point, despite this definition and explanation, you're probably still wondering what exactly content marketing is. We can get more clarity by considering a few examples.

Five Content Marketing Examples

There are as many types of content marketing as there are types of content--far too many to cover here. My intent is to give you an introduction to content marketing and get you thinking like a content marketer so you'll see the opportunities all around you. Soon you'll be coming up with 50 content marketing ideas every day. You won't be able to stop seeing opportunities to create content. Here are five examples to help your mind start percolating.

Infographics. These are generally long, vertical graphics that include statistics, charts, graphs, and other information. If you need some examples, here are 197 infographics on the topic of content marketing curated by Michael Schmitz, head of Content Lab at Publicis, Munich. Infographics can be effective in that if one is good it can be passed around social media and posted on websites for years. You can get a professionally designed infographic by hiring a contractor on a site like oDesk or if you want to remove some of the risk you can go with a company like Visua.ly. A decent infographic will usually cost you at least \$1,000 to have designed, but can cost several thousand dollars if you are hiring a contractor or agency to include strategy and planning, research, copywriting, and design. There is also the matter of promoting that infographic to bloggers and the media. Or you could set up a board on Pinterest and

curate infographics on a topic related to your business. That is also a form of content marketing, and it costs nothing but your time. Hey, it worked for Michael.

Webpages. What's the difference between a normal webpage and a webpage that is content marketing? Consider The Beginner's Guide to SEO from Moz, a provider of SEO related tools and resources. This resource, offered for free, has been viewed millions of times, bringing in countless customers who otherwise might never have stumbled across Moz and the services they offer. Or take a look at a case study from the design firm Teehan+Lax. Most case studies are boring. Their case studies are fascinating. That's the difference between simply putting content on your website, and content marketing.

Podcasts. Michael Hyatt, author of the best-selling book *Platform: Get Noticed in a Noisy World*, practices what he preaches. His "This is Your Life" podcast is downloaded 250,000 times each month. As Hyatt elaborates on his blog post *4 Reasons You Should Consider Launching Your Own Podcast*, "A podcast gives you visibility in a completely different world—primarily iTunes. I have had scores of new people say they had never heard of me until they stumbled onto me in iTunes." Hyatt gives valuable information and advice in his podcast—all for free. But that podcast leads to more sales of his books, signups for his courses, and requests for him as a speaker.

Videos. Gary Vaynerchuk is a master of content marketing using online video, just take a look at his YouTube channel. He got his start creating videos to promote his family's wine store and through those videos and other online marketing he eventually grew it to a \$45M empire. Videos and podcasts are a largely untapped form of content marketing because people think it's expensive and hard. But with the falling cost of professional grade equipment creating high quality video and audio content is easier than ever. Amateur video content marketing has been used to sell blenders, launch new dental products, and market Hong Kong visa consulting services. What video could you throw together for your company that might change your fortunes overnight? It might be easier than you think.

Books. Like movies, people often think of books as selling themselves, but savvy marketers don't sell books just to sell books, they sell books as marketing tools. Michael Port's sales manual *Book Yourself Solid* is a great read for entrepreneurs, salespeople, and marketers, and while I'm sure Port enjoys selling his book, the book is a tool for driving customers to his coaching and speaking services. Although with self-publishing it's easier than ever to publish a book, there is still the perception that it's difficult and that only reputable professionals can publish a business book. Publish your own, and even if people don't read it you can still use it as a form of content marketing every time you're introduced as "Author of..."

Those are just a few examples of content marketing. I could also have mentioned white papers, ebooks, apps, public speaking, presentations, and blogs. Entire books have been written on using each of these in content marketing efforts.